Lesson 04: Sentence Boundaries: Fragments, Run-ons and Comma Splices

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 2.3: Sentence Structure Boundaries and Associated Errors; 2.5: Refining Your Writing (Exercises).

In this lesson

You met fragments, run-ons and comma splices at B2. At C1 the challenge is different: these errors hide in long, complex sentences and in fast writing such as e-mails and exam answers. You review the common causes of fragments and the ways to correct run-ons, and then edit longer passages, choosing the correction that best shows the relationship between ideas.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Recognize fragments that begin with a preposition, a dependent word, an -ing word or an infinitive, and correct them.
- Distinguish a fused sentence from a comma splice.
- Correct run-ons with a period, a semicolon (with or without a transition word), a comma and a coordinating conjunction, or a dependent word.
- Edit a dense, rambling paragraph, choosing corrections that show how the ideas are related.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
fragment	an incomplete sentence: the subject or verb is missing, or it does not make sense on its own	Told her about the broken vase.
dependent word	a word that begins a dependent clause	since, if, because, when, although, even though, after, unless
gerund	an -ing verb form used as a noun	Working without taking a break … (*taking* is a gerund after the preposition *without*)
infinitive	to + a verb (used as a noun, an adjective or an adverb)	to run, to write, to reach
run-on sentence	independent clauses that are incorrectly combined (in this book: fused sentences and comma splices)	The new printer was installed, no one knew how to use it.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
fused sentence	two complete sentences combined with no punctuation	A family of foxes lived under our shed young foxes played all over the yard.
comma splice	two complete sentences joined only by a comma	We looked outside, the kids were hopping on the trampoline.
transition word	a word such as however or therefore that shows the connection between two thoughts	The project was put on hold; however, ...
dense / rambling	too full of information / going on too long without a clear direction	A reader can get lost or lose interest in material that is too dense and rambling.

Rules and explanations

Fragments

A fragment is missing a subject or a verb, or it does not make sense on its own. Fix it by adding the missing part, or by joining it to a sentence next to it.

- "Told her about the broken vase." → "I told her about the broken vase." (subject added)
- "The store down on Main Street." → "The store down on Main Street sells music." (verb added)

Fragments often begin with one of four kinds of words:

Fragment begins with	How to fix it	Example
a preposition	join it to a sentence: at the end, or at the beginning followed by a comma	(pictures in the book; see Practice 1, item 5)
a dependent word (since, if, because, when, although, even though, after, unless)	join it to an independent clause: at the beginning + comma, or at the end	(pictures in the book; see Practice 1, item 3)
an -ing word	join it to a sentence, or add a subject and a helping verb	Taking deep breaths. Saul prepared for his presentation. → Taking deep breaths, Saul prepared for his presentation.
an infinitive (to + verb)	join it to a sentence, or add the missing parts	We needed to make three hundred more paper cranes. To reach the one thousand mark. → ... paper cranes to reach the one thousand mark. / ... We wanted to reach the one thousand mark.

Notes for precise editing:

- An -ing word works as a verb only with a helping verb (*was taking*). Without one, it is a noun (a gerund) or, as in "Taking deep breaths, Saul ...", an -ing modifier (Lesson 02). The book calls all of these "gerunds".

- The book lists *without* as a dependent word; it is a preposition, but the fix is the same.
- In one book correction, the pronoun comes before the name ("She was congratulating the entire team. Sarah raised ..."); better: "Sarah was congratulating the entire team. She raised ...".

Run-ons: fused sentences and comma splices

- A **fused sentence** has no punctuation between two complete sentences; a **comma splice** has only a comma. The book calls both **run-ons**; a whole paragraph can run on (see the "good communicator" example in the material).
- A long sentence is not automatically a run-on. A sentence with one independent clause and many phrases can be correct.

Ways to correct a run-on

The simplest way is a period, which makes two separate sentences. The other ways:

Method	Run-on	Correction
a semicolon	The accident closed both lanes of traffic we waited an hour for the wreckage to be cleared.	The accident closed both lanes of traffic; we waited an hour for the wreckage to be cleared.
a semicolon + transition word + comma	The project was put on hold we didn't have time to slow down, so we kept working.	The project was put on hold; however, we didn't have time to slow down, so we kept working.
a comma + coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS)	The new printer was installed, no one knew how to use it.	The new printer was installed, but no one knew how to use it.
a dependent word	We took the elevator, the others still got there before us.	Although we took the elevator, the others got there before us.
a dependent word	Cobwebs covered the furniture, the room hadn't been used in years.	Cobwebs covered the furniture because the room hadn't been used in years.

- Use a semicolon only when both parts are independent clauses and the ideas are closely related.
- The book's heading "Dependent Words (Conjunctive Adverbs)" mixes two groups of words. *Although* and *because* are subordinating conjunctions: they can join two clauses with a comma or with no punctuation. Conjunctive adverbs such as *however* and *therefore* cannot: they need a semicolon or a period before them.
- Choose the method by meaning (Lesson 03): a period or a semicolon for two separate points, a FANBOYS word for equal ideas, a dependent word when one idea is the main point.
- Isabelle's e-mail is a picture that is not in your printed material. The book's point: readers may think less of a writer whose e-mails contain fragments and run-ons, or may not understand them. Before you press "send", check every sentence boundary.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
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> - Arabic punctuation allows long sentences whose clauses are joined with commas and "and". In English, a comma alone cannot join two independent clauses, so this habit produces comma

> splices. After every comma, ask: does a new subject and verb begin here?

Practice

1. Fragments (lesson material, 2.3, first exercise). Find the fragment in each item. Then combine it with the independent clause to create a complete sentence.

1. Working without taking a break. We try to get as much work done as we can in an hour.
2. I needed to bring work home. In order to meet the deadline.
3. Unless the ground thaws before spring break. We won't be planting any tulips this year.
4. Turning the lights off after he was done in the kitchen. Mohammed tries to conserve energy whenever possible.
5. You'll find what you need if you look. On the shelf next to the potted plant.
6. To find the perfect apartment. Thuy scoured the classifieds each day.

2. Run-on passages (2.3, the "Example" after the e-mail discussion). Correct the run-ons in the three passages: (1) the report that is due on Wednesday, (2) Ana's restaurant reservation, (3) Leonardo da Vinci.

3. The communication paragraph (2.3, the last "Example"). Edit the paragraph that begins "Communication is a big topic ..." to fix the run-on issues.

4. Refining your writing (2.5, item 1). Fix the paragraph that begins "I can't live without my Mom ..." using the methods in this lesson.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here are my corrections of the three run-on passages: [paste]. Did I find every run-on? Is my punctuation correct?"
- "Write a 150-word paragraph about sleep and memory with six hidden boundary errors: two fragments, two fused sentences and two comma splices. I will find and correct them."
- "Here is an e-mail I want to send: [paste]. Check the sentence boundaries, as the book advises, but let me make the corrections."
- (Book group activity, 2.5, item 5) "Here is a paragraph from an academic article: [paste]. Does the writer use sentence variety, coordination and subordination effectively? Help me rewrite the weakest part."

Writing task

Choose one of the book's tasks (2.5, items 2 and 3).

- **Real-life writing.** Collect two short real-life samples (an e-mail, junk mail, a company report, a social networking page, a local newspaper, a public notice, or a popular psychology article online) that lack sentence variety or contain boundary errors. Highlight what you would edit and explain

why. Then rewrite one sample in 150 to 200 words. Replace any recognizable name with a pseudonym (a fictitious name).

- **Children's story.** Rewrite one page (about 200 words) of a story for eight- to ten-year-olds, which uses short, simple sentences, for slightly older readers. Use the techniques of Lessons 02 and 03 without creating fragments or run-ons. Then compare the versions: how does sentence variety change the audience?

Self-editing checklist:

- Every sentence has a subject and a verb and makes sense on its own.
- No group of words that begins with a preposition, a dependent word, an -ing word or an infinitive stands alone as a sentence.
- No two independent clauses are joined with nothing (fused) or with only a comma (comma splice).
- A semicolon has an independent clause on both sides.
- *However*, *therefore* and other conjunctive adverbs follow a semicolon or a period, not just a comma.
- A dependent clause at the start of a sentence is followed by a comma.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

1. The fragment is the first part in items 1, 3, 4 and 6, and the second part in items 2 and 5.

1. Working without taking a break, we try to get as much work done as we can in an hour.
2. I needed to bring work home in order to meet the deadline. (Also: In order to meet the deadline, I needed to bring work home.)
3. Unless the ground thaws before spring break, we won't be planting any tulips this year. (Also: We won't be planting any tulips this year unless the ground thaws before spring break.)
4. Turning the lights off after he was done in the kitchen, Mohammed tries to conserve energy whenever possible. (Better style, with matching tenses: Mohammed tries to conserve energy whenever possible, turning the lights off after he is done in the kitchen.)
5. You'll find what you need if you look on the shelf next to the potted plant.
6. To find the perfect apartment, Thuy scoured the classifieds each day. (Also: Thuy scoured the classifieds each day to find the perfect apartment.)

2. (example answers; other correct punctuation is possible)

- Passage 1: The report is due on Wednesday, but we're flying back from Miami that morning. I told the project manager that we would be able to get the report to her later that day. She suggested that we come back a day early to get the report done, and I told her we had meetings until our flight took off. We e-mailed our contact, who said that he would check with his boss. She said that the project could afford a delay as long as they wouldn't have to make any edits or changes to the file. Our new deadline is next Friday. (Five boundary corrections: two fused sentences, one comma splice, and commas before *but* and *and*. Also improved: a comma before *who*, and *he* instead of *they* to agree with *his boss*.)
- Passage 2: Ana tried getting a reservation at the restaurant, but when she called, they said that there was a waiting list, so she put our names down on the list. When the day of our reservation arrived, we only had to wait thirty minutes because a table opened up unexpectedly. This was good because we were able to catch a movie after dinner in the time we'd expected to wait to be seated. (Also correct: "..., which was good because ..." instead of a new sentence.)
- Passage 3: the first sentence is long but correct (one independent clause). The fused sentence is "... the computer enhanced versions researchers use ...". Correction: ... especially when you see the computer-enhanced versions. Researchers use a variety of methods to discover and enhance the paintings' original colors, the results of which are stunningly vibrant and yet delicate displays of the man's genius. (Also improved: *computer-enhanced* takes a hyphen before a noun, and *the results ... are* agree.)

3. The run-on points: "two pages, in conclusion" (comma splice); "the way of life it can" (fused); "reply to you, we all can" (comma splice); "before we speak that's why" (fused); "two ears talk less" (fused). (example answer) Communication is such a big topic that I could write up to two pages if I kept going. In conclusion, communication is a way of life. It can reveal one's feelings and emotions, and that's where body language comes in. You can tell if someone is paying attention to you by the way they are

sitting, looking or even answering you. We can all be good communicators if we listen more before we speak. That's why we have one mouth and two ears: talk less and listen more. (Other changes: "a big topic that if I keep going I could write" is not grammatical, so it becomes *such ... that*; *ones'* becomes *one's*; "paying attention to you speak" becomes "paying attention to you"; *detect* becomes *reveal*, because people detect feelings and communication shows them.)

4. Problems: sentence 1 joins two long clauses with *and* but no comma before *and*, and the logic is unclear (the divorce is not really why the writer cannot live without their mother), so split it; "After my parents got separated" needs a comma, and *after* does not fit the present perfect (*since* does); "She is my really good friend I can share ..." is a fused sentence. (example answer) I can't live without my Mom. My parents got divorced in 2012, and since that day, my Mom has sacrificed her life to give me a better life. Since my parents separated, she has never said no to me. She is a really good friend; I can share anything with her, and she always guides me through it.

My notes